GOA

Lost His Paes?

With his trademark Jack-in-the-box enthusiasm, Leander Paes had rushed to the forecourt. In November, just a month after formally joining the Trinamool Congress (TMC) in the presence of Mamata Banerjee, the tennis ace virtually hit the campaign trail—meeting voters across all walks of life in Velim constituency, south Goa. He got a rousing welcome as he met people early morning, interacting with fisherfolk and promising to resolve their problems if the TMC is voted to power.

The 1996 Atlanta Olympic bronze medalist had focused on Velim—named after a large village mentioned in old Konkan/Kannada chronicles—because his father Vece, the former India hockey midfielder who played in the 1972 Munich Olympics, hails from the village. Paes projected himself as a son of the soil who has returned to his roots after spending most of his life outside—first in Calcutta, where he was born, then in Mumbai. That flurry of net action, naturally, meant he wished to contest—and he openly expressed that desire. But of late, Paes has vanished from the scene. The TMC has now fielded Benjamin Silva, a Congress turncoat, from Velim. ■

FISHY AFFAIR Paes out and about in Velim



ANI



GOA

IT'S RAINING REBELS

Tired of hung assemblies? Dying to see a comfortable majority? Well, Goa has it already. A whopping 29 of the 40 members of its outgoing assembly have switched sides since 2017—some 14 of them in this very season. Cumulatively, these worthies could well stake claim to form a Government of Defectors. Though, of course, it would be counter-logical to form a party of defectors—if its members stay loyal to the ideology, they can no longer hang around together! But this is not just a theoretical game. Come February 14, these rebels may play a crucial role in forming the next government—poised as they are to swing 12-15 constituencies.

Though reminiscent of the late '90s-early 2000s, a phase of intense uncertainty that pushed Goa back on the development front, the numbers are unprecedented. The trend caught on even before the outgoing assembly was constituted in March 2017. Vishwajeet Rane quit the Congress because it failed